

{Head} When teachers learn

{Intro} Professional teachers beat neglected facilitators every school day of the week, write Pim Pollen and Ben Laker

{Body}

Student-led projects and DIY learning strategies might have found new popularity in 21st century Education – but without professional, knowledgeable, engaged teachers, such strategies will see students (and schools) fail.

Take heart, then, in our latest research: teachers want more support, more knowledge and improved skills. They want to be ready for the 21st century Education. They want to be the best they can be.

{Box-out} Pop quiz

Q: What is the number one indicator of student performance in reading and math?

A: Teacher quality

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Most school governors and board members around the world have no link to education beyond their time spent as students. With no experience behind a teacher's desk, they cannot be expected to intuit nor anticipate the challenges and opportunities of contemporary education. But the people who do – educators themselves – are rarely asked for their input at this level.

Almost 75,000 teachers and support staff from The Netherlands, Italy, Germany, Turkey, South Africa and Mozambique responded to our request for more information about their roles and challenges. Using self-assessments of the group's knowledge-competencies, skills and ambitions, we have been able to put together a complete picture of how teachers see themselves and, importantly, how they would like to grow in the years to come.

{Graphic box-out} The results are in

What we can do

- ✓ Manage behaviour
- ✓ Maintain pedagogical climates
- ✓ Prepare learning activities
- ✓ Foster a healthy learning attitude in the classroom
- ✓ Maintain optimum contact with students
- ✓ Encourage social and emotional development
- ✓ Preserve well-being
- ✓ Incorporate the perspective of parents into own

What we can't do

- ⇓ Use evidence-based research effectively
- ⇓ Embrace innovative capabilities
- ⇓ Embed and implement preventive programs
- ⇓ Knowledge of current educational and behavioural science
- ⇓ Knowledge of current developmental psychology and inclusive education
- ⇓ Knowledge of developments in society
- ⇓ Different methods for cooperation

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In general, teachers believe they are people-people, with a good grasp of interpersonal and organizational competencies. They also pride themselves on being resourceful and capable of working together with the environment and parents.

Where teachers see themselves failing, however, is in whether or not they have enough knowledge of a subject, evidence-based educational and behaviour sciences, and developments in society.

Without speculating on the cause of this (for teachers) confidence-busting and (for parents and students) inconvenient truth, the reality that our teachers do not believe they have enough knowledge is worrying, to say the least.

And, facing bursting classrooms, the future's many distractions and ever-deepening budget cuts, now is the time for leadership to act.

{Graphic box-out} What teachers want to learn

Teachers want to attain the highest levels of specific skills such as:

- ⇒ Communicating with parents
- ⇒ Finding help for student development problems
- ⇒ Devising and enforcing more rules for dealing with behaviour
- ⇒ Giving students more space
- ⇒ Preparing for learning activities

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With analyses of the opinions and insights of teachers actively serving students every day, leadership has the opportunity to determine starting points and quantifiable aims for professional development.

Allowing teachers to self-report professional development ambitions also provides valuable insight into how effective – or not – a strategy really is. For example, we asked the sample to rate their progress towards annual goals. Such insights could prove especially valuable as showing results of teacher professional development in student test scores could take time.

{Graphic box-out} The long and winding road

Teachers see themselves as far from these ambitions today as ever

- Evaluating and reflecting on learning goals after lessons
- Being aware of and understanding one's thought processes (metacognition)
- Conducting and understanding evidence-based research
- Developing self-efficacy/responsibility
- Inclusive education
- Having knowledge of current educational and behavioural science
- Being up to date with developmental science and inclusive education
- Having a strong grasp of learning objectives and strategies
- Producing useful extra lesson materials

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{Xhead} Join the learning community

Sharing teacher insights can also foster arguably the most effective learning strategy around: the professional learning community (PLC). The professional development equivalent of high performing teams in organizations, PLCs are groups of teachers who commit to the achievement of better learning outcomes for pupils. In perfect PLCs, members undertake dedicated research and share learnings with each other, shifting their focus from didactic, one-way transfers of information to continuous learning as a team. Profoundly affecting the practices of schooling, PLCs are primarily for the benefit of students, and act as self-sustaining, sharing communities in which all teachers embrace continuous improvement and learning.

{Box-out} Characteristics of the perfect PLC

- Strongly oriented towards action and results
- Culture of collaboration
- Key shared goals based on qualitative data
- Shared leadership
- Explorative student interventions

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{Xhead} Hire an Architect

With the introduction of PLCs and other professional development approaches, teachers – and entire schools – may quickly find themselves part of one tier, as educated educators, or the other, neglected facilitators. Connecting two tiers in the real-world means asking architects to design a bridge. The same approach applies in the world of teacher professional development.

Mentioned first by Hill, Mellon, Laker and Goddard last year in Harvard Business Review and *Dialogue*, Architects are the type of leaders who thrive when it comes to long-term continuous improvement. Quietly redesigning their schools and systems to create the right environment for teachers, students and community, Architects are the people who give up their spot on a life raft and find a sustainable solution to the problem at hand.

Architects, therefore, with their quiet, sustainable transformation strategies and determination to install a positive movement and legacy, are arguably the only leaders who can successfully foster professional development across the school and wider system in the long term.

It is a style school leadership must quickly adapt or attain if students' education is to shine.

{Xhead} Small steps for teachers and a giant leap for Learning

Many have argued the lack of professionalism and increase in scale within education combine to see the role of 'teacher' impoverished and simplified. Were the smaller steps discussed here successfully adopted into the education system, teachers and school leadership may wish to co-operate at a higher level: Together, they could take one giant leap towards formal empowerment, such as allowing teachers ownership of the curriculum and related professionalization.

Evolving curricula to incorporate the professional opinions and experience of teachers could also address three major capabilities that teachers are determined to gain, yet are significantly far from obtaining.

The case for curriculum ownership:

- Being able to put learning goals into context for students will greatly affect understanding and impact of education
- Greater responsibility for teachers could ignite passion for a subject and more energy in the classroom

But the most valuable information teachers can provide to curriculum boards can only be divined by asking them the right questions – so we implore you to make time to ask the school community where they are right now, and where they need to be.

{Xhead} High Performing Schools: You may begin

Obtaining the best from students first requires schools to attain the best from their teachers. Accelerating professional development is going to require the gaining and growing of professional knowledge and classroom skills to improve Learning.

The most effective strategies will involve designing professional development based on the views and capabilities of teachers themselves, and allowing educators to grow both formally and informally in new, innovative ways. This might require Architect leaders to come to the fore, and will certainly need long-term sustainable transformation school-wide, at all levels of community and leadership – to the benefit of teachers, students and schools for years to come.

{Credit} Pim Pollen is senior advisor of the Academica Business College with a focus on transforming schools into high performing schools. Dr Ben Laker is a best-selling author, acclaimed researcher and Hollywood Oscars commentator.

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{Further reading}

- Hill, A., Mellon, L., Laker, B., & Goddard, J. (2016). The one type of leader who can turn around a failing school. Harvard Business Review, 20.
- Hill, A., Mellon, L., Laker, B., & Goddard, J. (2017). How the best school leaders create enduring change. Harvard Business Review.
- Marzano, R. J., Waters, T., & McNulty, B. A. (2005). School leadership that works: From research to results. ASCD.
- Darling-Hammond, L. (2000) Teacher Quality and Student Achievement: A Review of State Policy Evidence. Education Policy Analysis Archives, 8 (1).
- Sanders, W. L. and Rivers, J. C. (1996). Cumulative and Residual Effects of Teachers on Future Student Academic Achievement. Research Progress Report, University of Tennessee, USA.
- William, D. (2016). Leadership for Teacher Learning. Learning Science International
- Evers J. and Kneyber R. (2016). Flip the System. Routledge
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{Close further reading}

{Box-out} Asking questions

74,403 primary, secondary and tertiary level teachers and supportive staff from The Netherlands, Germany, Italy, Turkey, South-Africa and Mozambique completed the Professionalism Scanner (Prof Scan) web-based questionnaire that asked them to rate and evaluate themselves. Consisting of ± 70 questions spanning 40 competencies, each derived from international research on education.

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{Box-out} The building blocks of high performing schools

- Long-term vision
- Effective leadership
- Quality of teachers
- Open and action orientated
- Continuous improvement and innovation

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Guidance Sheet

Relaxation

How to use the video



Who is the video for?

The video is for people with learning disabilities who might be feeling down, anxious or struggling to cope with the coronavirus pandemic and restrictions. It is designed to show people who might be feeling worried, tense or worked up how they can relax and help themselves feel calm. The relaxation exercise shown in the video will help anyone. If family, friends or support staff want to do the relaxation alongside the person with a learning disability they might find it's nice to do as well.

Who can help people with learning disabilities use the video and how do they do it?

This guide is for people who can help the person with a learning disability. These can be family members, friends, or support staff. It is also suitable for social care staff and health professionals.

The video can be used in a number of ways depending on the individual circumstances of the person with a learning disability. You can meet face to face if social distancing restrictions allow, remotely by phone, or using online video links such as zoom or skype or mobile phone apps, if you and the person with a learning disability have internet or enough mobile data.

Start by talking about being anxious and worked up. You might need to find out the words people use for being anxious. Sometimes people talk about being 'stressed', 'worried' or 'wound up', sometimes people say they feel 'jittery' and 'can't settle'.

Talk about the fact that everyone can get anxious. When this happens we can get worked up and our bodies can feel tense. Talk to the person about what happens to their bodies when they get anxious. They might breathe faster, feel a bit hot, their hearts might beat louder and faster, they might feel shaky, they might get butterflies in their stomach or they might need to go to the toilet more often. Not everyone feels the same way when they are anxious. Talk to the person about how they feel when they get worried or anxious.

Ask the person if there are times they feel happier, calm, quiet or relaxed. See if there are things they do that help them to feel better. For example, some people might watch favourite TV programmes, listen to music, look at photographs, stroke or play with a pet cat or dog, have a warm bath or a shower. Some people might just sit quietly. If the person feels they are getting more upset or worked up then they might be able to do relaxing activities that help them feel better.

What is this video about and how can it help?

Some people who are anxious find that their bodies feel very tense and worked up. Relaxation is a way to help people's bodies feel better and calm. Learning to relax is just like learning to do any other skill. It takes practice and it takes time. If you get a chance, watch the video yourself before you show it to the person you support, so you know how it works. Make some time to talk to the person you support about relaxation. For some people, learning to relax will be part of learning how to manage anxiety and will help when they get

worked up. For other people, doing relaxation will just be a nice thing to do with people they get on well with or who support them.

How to use the video

The video is a way for people to learn to feel relaxed. Relaxation needs to be done regularly. People find that the more they do it they get better at it. The video isn't very long, so plan to watch the video with the person 2 or 3 times a day. At first it might be quite hard, but if the person uses the video for a week then they will find it starts to get easier.

Choose a time when it is quiet in the house to watch the video. Ask the person you are supporting to wear some comfortable clothes. Ask them to sit in a chair that supports their back or to lie down on a bed or sofa, with a cushion to support their head. The person in the video can do the relaxation exercise sitting down but it can just as easily be done lying down. Make sure that the person can see the video when they are playing it. After you've watched it together a few times, it might be enough just to listen to what the person on the video is saying.

It will probably help if you (friend, family member or support worker) do the relaxation as well. You might find you enjoy it just as much!

If the person becomes upset

Relaxation is for everyone, whether they are feeling anxious or not. However some people might be feeling a bit upset or be struggling emotionally. So it's understandable if people become a bit upset when doing the relaxation exercises. However, if there are serious concerns about someone's mental health or if they are at serious risk of harming themselves or others then their GP should be contacted.

Other booklets and resources

Before you use this video read through the Introductory booklet with the person you are supporting. It tells you about the other booklets you can look through. They show different ways of helping the person to feel better. You will find the relaxation video, along with these other resources, at the Scottish Commission for People with Learning Disabilities <https://www.scll.org.uk/information-on-coronavirus/> and at NES Scotland <https://www.nes.scot.nhs.uk>

This booklet has been adapted from StepUp, a guided self help intervention for people with learning disabilities and depression. You can look at the online training for StepUp which includes video clips.

Online modules and the manual on StepUp can be found at NES Scotland,

<https://learn.nes.nhs.scot/15095/learning-disabilities/talking-therapies-for-depression-step-up>

and NHS Education England.

<https://www.e-lfh.org.uk/programmes/intellectual-disability-and-depression-talking-therapies/>

Feedback

If you have any feedback or thoughts about the booklets then we would really like to hear from you. You can contact ihw-cope@glasgow.ac.uk

